

Part III — The Fountain

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The Step-Daughter takes the Child-bundle to the fountain. She bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it — but the basin's walls are high enough that nobody, neither the audience nor the live actors, can see inside it. The drowning happens in plain sight, in an unseeable space. The Son finally tells what he saw on that afternoon: he ran across the garden, he jumped to drag the Child out of the water, and he was frozen by the sight of the Boy standing stock still by the side of the fountain, his face stricken, watching his little sister in the water.

As the Son speaks, the stage lights drop slowly, breath by breath, until only the fountain's pale-blue interior and the bare hanging bulb above the Manager's table remain. The Boy-chair sits behind the basin where the Manager has placed it earlier in the act. For ten seconds, in that low water-light, the audience sees the silhouette of the chair against the cold water — the Boy watching his little sister in the water. Then full blackout. Then, out of the dark, the gunshot — from behind the basin, where the Boy-chair is. The Mother cries out. The actors lift what they think is the Boy's body, which is the Boy-chair now being treated as a body. Some say he is dead. Others say it is only pretence. The Father, with a terrible cry: *Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!* The Manager has had enough: he looks at the empty Boy-chair, says *Pretence? Reality? To hell with it all*, and walks out the way a man leaves a theatre. Curtain.

The climax is delivered as memory, not as scene. The drowning is hidden by the basin itself — its walls do the work the Step-Daughter's body used to do. The light fades until only the silhouette of a chair behind a basin remains: the act of watching, not the act of dying. Then the dark. Then the shot. This is Pirandello's strictest cruelty: the most terrible thing in the play is the thing the audience does not actually see happen.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

She wrests control of the staging from the Manager, carrying the Child to the fountain herself — the urgency of someone who knows exactly how this ends.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Wait a minute, wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... [*Lifts the Child-bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it to the fountain.*]

Approving blocking he does not understand, he files catastrophe under staging problems and moves efficiently on.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

*The **Second Lady Lead** and the **Juvenile Lead** at this point separate themselves from the group of **Actors**. One watches the **Mother** attentively; the other moves about studying the movements and manner of the **Son** whom he will have to act.*

Correcting the geography is the Son's way of refusing the emotional exposure entirely; factual accuracy is his last line of defence.

THE SON [*to **Manager***]. What do you mean by both at the same time? It isn't right. There was no scene between me and her. [*Indicates the **Mother***.] Ask her how it was!

Her brevity is not rhetoric but rupture — a wound reopening, incapable of argument.

THE MOTHER. Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

Insisting on the room over the garden is a territorial act: the garden belongs to theatre, the room belonged to him.

THE SON. Into my room. Do you understand? Not the garden. Nothing about this ever happened in the garden.

Dismissing truth for grouping, he shows theatre's quiet violence — reality must be shaped to fit the frame.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

Not curious — threatening; he feels his selfhood being measured and will not stand still for it.

THE SON *[observing the **Juvenile Lead** studying him]*. What do you want?

Innocent as the denial is, it only deepens the wound: being watched without malice is somehow worse than being judged.

PLAYER 3. Nothing! I was just looking at you.

He reads the actress's attention as predatory mimicry, collapsing the distance between imitation and violation.

THE SON *[turning towards the **Second Lady Lead**]*. Ah! she's at it too: to re-act her part! *[Indicating the **Mother**.]*

Cheerful and completely oblivious, he mistakes the Son's horror for ingratitude and the actors' surveillance for generosity.

THE MANAGER. Exactly! And it seems to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

Long suppressed, the outcry finally breaks: the mirror speech is not philosophy but a scream against the unbearable self-consciousness of being staged.

THE SON *[the cry he has been holding for the whole production — surprising himself]*. Yes — but haven't you yet perceived that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror? A mirror that doesn't only freeze us with the image of ourselves. It throws our likeness back at us — with a *horrible grimace*.

Agreement here is tactics — he validates the Son's anguish to neutralise the Son's resistance to re-enactment.

THE FATHER. That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

He moves the actors not out of empathy but craft; he has finally found a blocking note he can execute.

THE MANAGER *[to **Second Lady Lead** and **Juvenile Lead**]*. He's right! Move away from them!

Flat withdrawal, not dramatic exit — negation is the only act of autonomy the Son has left.

THE SON. Do as you like. I'm out of this!

He silences the Son and pivots to the Mother with professional briskness, treating her pain as exposition to be extracted.

THE MANAGER. Be quiet, you, will you? And let me hear your mother! *[To **Mother**.]* You were saying you had entered...

The hand at her chest is the speech beneath the speech; her body holds what words can barely begin.

THE MOTHER. Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me. All of it. *[A hand at her chest, briefly.]* But the moment he saw me...

Self-protective repetition: if he insists nothing happened often enough, perhaps the guilt of doing nothing will dissolve.

THE SON. Nothing happened! There was no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

She validates his version against herself — habitual self-erasure offering absolution he has not earned or asked for.

THE MOTHER. It's true, true. That's how it was.

He presses for the scene not because it matters emotionally but because the plot requires it; he is filling a structural gap.

THE MANAGER. Well now, we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

Heartbreaking in its smallness — she needs only a crack, a moment, to pour out what she has carried for years.

THE MOTHER. I'm ready. Whenever you are. If you could just find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here. *[Her hand at her chest.]*

His rage at the Son is also guilt redirected: he cannot bear what his own decisions have cost the Mother he claims to protect.

THE FATHER *[going to Son in a great rage]*. You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

Two words, flat affect — refusal so total it has passed through anger into something colder and more final.

THE SON *[flat]*. I do nothing.

When philosophy fails, he falls back on the bodily force he usually dresses as reason, shaking what words could not move.

THE FATHER *[taking hold of him and shaking him]*. For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

The counter-grip externalises the internal war: the Son refuses to be shaken into feeling, into someone else's story.

THE SON *[taking hold of the Father]*. No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else... *[General agitation.]*

The Mother, frightened, tries to separate them.

Not asking for peace — trying to keep her hands on what little remains; the plea is wordless and desperate.

THE MOTHER *[both hands on the Child-bundle, gripping it]*. Please! please!

Holding on past persuasion, the grip itself says what he cannot: he needs the scene performed to justify his own suffering.

THE FATHER *[not leaving hold of the Son]*. You've got to obey, do you hear?

His cracking voice betrays him even as his body refuses — invoking the absent author is a last defence, claiming the right to stay unwritten.

THE SON *[the voice cracking but the body refusing the cry]*. What does it mean — this madness you've got? *[They separate.]* Have you no decency? That you insist on showing everyone our shame? I won't do it. I won't. And I stand for the will of our author in this. He didn't want to put us on the stage. After all.

Genuinely confused, unable to process the Son's logic: his world has no room for unwilling characters.

THE MANAGER. Man alive! You came here...

Pointing at the Father, he performs the one act he permits himself — attribution of blame, testimony that costs him nothing staged.

THE SON *[indicating Father]*. He did! I didn't!

Unanswerable and he knows it: presence itself has become a trap the Son cannot argue his way out of.

THE MANAGER. Aren't you here now?

A legal brief disguised as accusation — he distinguishes fact from fiction to delegitimise everything the Father has performed as truth.

THE SON. It was his wish, and he dragged us along with him. He's told you not only the things that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

Procedural sequence is his tool: forcing the Son to narrate what he fled, testimony extracted by dramatic necessity.

THE MANAGER. Well, tell me then what did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

His single-sentence answer turns the old silence into a moral position; he avoided a scene then and is still trying to now.

THE SON. Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

The neutral prompt exploits narrative momentum, keeping the Son talking against his every instinct to stop.

THE MANAGER. And then what did you do?

The hesitation and gloom mean he has arrived at the memory he cannot refuse — the garden walk is the last step before horror.

THE SON. Nothing... walking in the garden... *[Hesitates for a moment with expression of gloom.]*

Gentleness here is almost predatory: he senses the reserve conceals something enormous and leans in like a man hunting the climax.

THE MANAGER *[coming closer to him, interested by his extraordinary reserve]*. Well, well... walking in the garden...

'Horrible' is aimed at himself — he is about to be forced to witness, again, what he could not prevent.

THE SON *[exasperated]. Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible! [The **Mother's** arms are empty — the Child-bundle is no longer in them, and she is the first in the room to feel its absence. Her hands close on nothing. She trembles, sobs, and looks towards the fountain before anyone has said why.]*

Three words, rising dread — he has finally understood, and the question carries the entire weight of what the fountain means.

THE MANAGER *[slowly observing the glance and turning towards the **Son** with increasing apprehension].* The baby?

The barest possible statement: he will not dramatise the drowning, but cannot withhold it; geography becomes elegy.

THE SON. There in the fountain...

Tender pity is also self-distancing — pointing at her grief draws attention away from his own failure to prevent it.

THE FATHER *[pointing with tender pity to the **Mother**].* She was following him at the moment...

No longer directing, he is dreading the answer; his 'and then you' is the audience's held breath made audible.

THE MANAGER *[to the **Son** anxiously].* And then you...

The stage lights drop slowly, breath by breath, beneath the Son's narration. By the end of it, only the fountain's pale-blue interior and the bare bulb above the Manager's table remain. The Boy-chair is silhouetted behind the basin.

Surrendering the story at last, he gives the room the image that has lived behind every refusal all evening: the Boy watching his sister drown.

THE SON *[the only continuous sentence he gives the room; he tells it because he cannot keep it inside any longer].* I ran over to her. I was jumping in — to drag her out — when I saw something that stopped me where I stood. The boy. Standing stock still. With a look on his face I will never forget. Watching his little sister, there in the water. *[The **Step-Daughter** bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it. The basin's walls hide the action from view. She sobs.]* Then... *[The fountain light holds for ten seconds on the silhouette of the Boy-chair behind the basin — the Boy watching. Then full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the Boy-chair is.]*

Lights snap back up at the cry that follows. The Boy is never seen dead — only the silhouette before, and the sound. What remains is the family, the company, the Manager, and the silence the audience has just been made to look into.

*The **Mother** does not cry out at once. She goes first to the basin and reaches down for the **Child-bundle** in the water; then, hearing the **Players** take up the **Boy-chair** behind her, she turns and reaches for that too. Her arms cannot hold both. The veil stays down over her face — she never lifts it herself, not even now. Only then does the sound come out of her.*

Every layer of performance stripped away — raw, ancient, maternal; the character and the wound are finally indistinguishable.

THE MOTHER. My son! My son! *[Then amid the cries and exclamations one hears her voice.]* Help! Help!

Half practical, half terrified, he is still trying to locate himself on the line between fiction and fact.

THE MANAGER *[pushing the **Players** aside while they lift up the Boy-chair and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible].* Is he really wounded?

They perform the news of death before they have processed it themselves — fact and theatre arriving simultaneously.

PLAYER 1 & PLAYER 3. He's dead! dead!

Clinging to pretence as a life raft, the reassurance is for themselves as much as anyone else in the room.

PLAYER 2. No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

His first uncontrolled moment: 'pretence' is the one wound no amount of philosophy can absorb.

THE FATHER *[with a terrible cry]*. Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!

Not a decision but a collapse — he leaves because he no longer knows what theatre is for.

THE MANAGER *[no commentary, no irony]*. Pretence? Reality? *[He looks at the empty Boy-chair.]* To hell with it all. *[He turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre.]*